

Pre-Cooked Food Canning

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Directions for Making Canned Boiled Peanuts

Step 1 - Select your peanuts

Select fully mature, but still green peanuts. They must not be roasted or already cooked or dried. Fully mature peanuts do not make good quality boiled peanuts; rather raw or "green" ones are used. "Raw" denotes peanuts in a semi-mature state, having achieved full size, but not being fully dried, as would be needed for roasting or peanut butter use. The most flavorful peanuts for boiling are the Valencia type. These are preferred in the United States, being grown in gardens and small patches throughout the South. Green Virginia type peanuts are also sometimes used - these do have larger kernels, but the flavor is not as good.

Step 2 - Prepare the jars and pressure canner



Wash the jars and lids

This is a good time to get the jars ready! The dishwasher is fine for the jars; especially if it has a "sanitize" cycle. Otherwise put the jars in boiling water for 10 minutes. I just put the lids in a small pot of almost boiling water for 5 minutes, and use the magnetic "lid lifter wand" (available from target, other big box stores, and often grocery stores; and available online - see this page) to pull them out.



Get a large pot of water boiling

We will use this water to pour over the peanuts and fill each jar with liquid, after we've packed them full of peanuts. I use the largest pot I have, so that there is plenty of clean, boiling water ready when I need it.

Get the pressure canner heating up

Rinse out your pressure canner, put the rack plate in the bottom, and fill it to a depth of 4 inches with hot tap water. (of course, follow the instruction that came with the canner, if they are different). Put it on the stove over low heat, with the lid OFF of it, just to get it heating up for later on.

Step 3 -Wash the peanuts

Wash them under running water.

Step 4 - Soak the peanuts

Soak the peanuts in the shell in fresh water for one hour.

Step 5 - Soak again

Discard the water, cover again with fresh water and soak for another hour.

Step 6 - Soak a third time!

Repeat this soaking process one more time for one more hour. This makes a total soaking time of three hours, using fresh water each time.

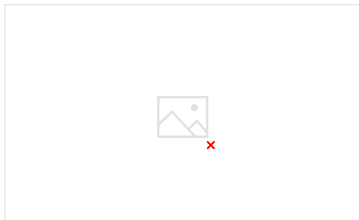
Step 7 - Make a brine solution

Combine 1 cup of pickling salt or kosher salt with 1 gallon of water. Set this on a burner on low heat (so it does not boil away) until you are ready to fill the jars (Step 10)

Step 8 - Parboil the peanuts

Then parboil the peanuts for 10 minutes in fresh water and drain. Parboiling means to maintain the stove's burner so that the water is simmering, just below boiling. This can be done inside on the stove or outside on a propane burner for a larger volume. The boil can go on longer than 10 minutes, depending on quantity and the age of the peanut (green "raw" peanuts cook faster and tend to be better tasting), but you do not want to boil so long that the peanuts become peanut butter! When they are soft, they are done. If they are still slightly crunchy, they are not done yet. Flavorings such as spices, hot sauce or Cajun seasonings can be added to the boil.

Step 9 - Fill the jars



Pack the hot peanuts into hot jars, leaving 1/2 inch headspace.

Step 10 - Add the hot brine

Fill each jar to 1/2 inch from the top with boiling brine (1 cup salt per gallon of water). Remove any air bubbles.

Step 11 - Seal the jars and fill the canner

Wipe the jar's rims, put the lids on then the rings and tighten them snugly. Place the jars into the pressure canner.

Step 12 - Let the pressure canner vent steam for 10 minutes

In order to prevent botulism it is imperative that boiled peanuts be canned inside a pressure canner. Botulism is a potentially fatal paralytic illness caused by a toxin produced by the bacteria *Clostridium botulinum*.

Myth: You do not have to use a pressure canner to can boiled peanuts.

Truth: Boiled peanuts, and other low acid foods must be canned in a pressure canner to prevent botulism.

Myth: Pressure cookers only serve to shorten cooking time, and are extremely dangerous.

Truth: Pressure cookers, and pressure canners raise the cooking temperature above that of boiling water. Boiling water is not hot enough to destroy *Clostridium botulinum* during canning. Modern pressure cookers, and pressure canners are safe when use according to the manufacturers' directions, and feature multiple safety mechanisms.

Myth: You can water bath can almost anything, which is basically making a bunch of little pressure cookers of your jars but limiting temp and pressure considerably.

Truth: A canning water bath is not "basically making a bunch of little pressure cookers". The temperatures developed in the jars is too low to destroy *Clostridium botulinum* during the canning process.